

Pawn islands count connected files

Chess Math

THE IDEA

A pawn island is a group of friendly pawns on adjacent files, separated from another group by at least one empty file. Fewer islands often make defense easier. Doubled pawns still occupy a single file and do not create an extra island by themselves.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Pawns on a2, b3, d4, f2, and g3 form three islands: ab, d, and fg. If the d-pawn disappears, two islands remain, but losing a pawn is hardly an improvement by itself.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

How many islands are formed by pawns on a2, a3, c2, d3, and h2?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Three: the a-file, the c-d files, and the h-file. Two pawns on a count as one occupied-file group. Then assess whether the gaps can actually be attacked.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Structure statistics need targets and activity to become an evaluation.